

Speech-to-text pricing: gpt-realtime-whisper vs gpt-4o-mini-transcribe

Prices from OpenAI's official API pricing page, checked 5 October 2026. Rupee figures use ₹95.96 per US dollar.

gpt-realtime-whisper \$0.017 per minute of audio · ₹1.63/min Live transcription: streams text while the person is speaking. Billed by audio duration.	gpt-4o-mini-transcribe \$0.003 per minute of audio · ₹0.29/min Transcription of recorded or finished audio. Billed by tokens: \$1.25 / 1M audio input, \$5.00 / 1M text output. Per-minute figure is OpenAI's estimate.
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5.7× **gpt-4o-mini-transcribe is about 5.7 times cheaper** per minute. gpt-realtime-whisper costs more because it transcribes live, word by word, instead of after the audio is complete.

Side by side

	gpt-realtime-whisper	gpt-4o-mini-transcribe
Price per minute	\$0.017	\$0.003
Price per hour	\$1.02	\$0.18
Billing unit	Audio minutes	Tokens (audio in, text out)
Best for	Live captions during a call	Transcripts after a call or recording
When text appears	While the person is still speaking	After the audio segment is sent
API endpoint	Realtime transcription sessions	Audio transcriptions

Cost at scale

A two-person call transcribes both voices, so each call minute is 2 audio minutes.

Usage	gpt-realtime-whisper	gpt-4o-mini-transcribe	Saving with mini
1 call minute (2 voices)	\$0.034 · ₹3.26	\$0.006 · ₹0.58	\$0.028
10-minute call	\$0.340 · ₹32.63	\$0.060 · ₹5.76	\$0.280
1,000 call minutes	\$34.00 · ₹3,262.64	\$6.00 · ₹575.76	\$28.00
10,000 call minutes	\$340.00 · ₹32,626.40	\$60.00 · ₹5,757.60	\$280.00

What this means for our app

- **Live captions need streaming.** Showing words on screen while someone talks requires gpt-realtime-whisper; gpt-4o-mini-transcribe only returns text once a piece of audio is finished.
- **Saved transcripts or summaries after a call** do not need streaming, so gpt-4o-mini-transcribe does the same job for about a sixth of the price.
- **Our current Gemini backend** already returns the text of what was said and its translation as part of translation, so live captions on Gemini need neither model.

Sources: developers.openai.com/api/docs/pricing (Transcription models), developers.openai.com/api/docs/models/gpt-realtime-whisper, developers.openai.com/api/docs/models/gpt-4o-mini-transcribe. Prices are list prices before tax and can change; check the pricing page before budgeting.